Claims Payment Policy

Subject: Modifier 50

Application: Medicare Advantage Products
Policy number: CP2007013
Related policies: Common CPT and HCPCS Modifiers

Effective date: 12/2007
Revision date: 07/2026

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Overview

This policy outlines Humana's billing requirements for *modifier 50* and reimbursement for services reported with *modifier 50*.

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Medicare Advantage Payment Policy

In addition to the policy, claims payments are subject to other plan requirements for the processing and payment of claims, including, but not limited to, requirements of medical necessity and reasonableness and applicable referral or authorization requirements.

The following policy applies to professional services only.

Billing

Bilateral procedures are procedures that are performed on similar sites on opposite sides of the body, during the same session, by the same qualified health care practitioner. When a procedure reported using a service code with a *Medicare Physician Fee Schedule (MPFS) Relative Value File (RVF)* bilateral indicator 1 is performed bilaterally, providers must report the code with either *modifier 50* or with anatomical modifiers such as *modifiers LT* and *RT*. Humana strongly encourages providers to report a bilateral procedure using *modifier 50* rather than *modifiers LT* and *RT*, but accepts both methods. When using *modifier 50* to report a bilateral procedure, report a single claim line with a unit of 1. When using *modifiers LT* and *RT* to report a bilateral procedure, report two claim lines, each with a unit of 1.

Only report *modifier 50* when the procedure is performed on similar but opposite sites. For example, report *modifier 50* for the same service code for a procedure performed on the right and left knee. However, do not report *modifier 50* for the same service code for a procedure performed on the right knee and left shoulder.

When reporting two or more bilateral procedures using the same code, report the first bilateral procedure on a single claim line with a unit of 1 using *modifier 50* and report a single claim line with a unit of 1 for all subsequent bilateral procedures using *modifier 50* and *modifier 59.*

It is not necessary to report *modifier 50* with a service code with an *MPFS RVF* bilateral indicator other than 1.

Special considerations for billing modifier 50 with certain anatomical modifiers

Report *modifier 50* in addition to eyelid, finger and toe modifiers on one claim line with a unit of 1 for procedures performed bilaterally on similar but opposite sites.

Examples that are considered bilateral and should be billed with the appropriate anatomical modifiers and *modifier 50*:

- Upper left eyelid and upper right eyelid: Report modifiers E1 and E3 with *modifier 50*
- Left hand, third digit and right hand, third digit: Report modifiers F2 and F7 with *modifier 50*
- Left foot, great toe and right foot, great toe: Report modifiers TA and T5 with *modifier 50*

Examples that are not considered bilateral and should be billed as two claim lines, each with a unit of 1, with the appropriate anatomical modifiers but not with *modifier 50*:

- Upper left eyelid and lower right eyelid: Report modifiers E1 and E4
- Left hand, third digit and right hand, fourth digit: Report modifiers F2 and F8
- Left foot, great toe and right foot, third digit: Report modifiers TA and T7

Reimbursement

Humana only applies a bilateral payment adjustment to procedures reported using a service code with a *MPFS RVF* bilateral indicator 1. When a bilateral payment adjustment applies, the amount allowed for a bilaterally performed procedure is the lesser of the following:

- The total charged for both sides; or
- 150 percent of either
  - the provider's contracted rate that would have applied if the procedure had been done unilaterally or
  - the *base maximum amount payable under the member's plan*, for an out-of-network provider, that would have applied if the procedure had been done unilaterally.

A single claim line with an *MPFS RVF* bilateral indicator 1 code billed with *modifier 50* is processed as one unit. Providers may submit supporting documentation for reconsideration of additional units.

In certain circumstances, additional payment rules may apply. For example, when a bilaterally performed procedure is reported with another procedure for the same date of service, a multiple procedure payment reduction may be applied after the bilateral payment adjustment. In such cases, the bilaterally performed procedure is considered one unit.

Examples

Bilateral payment adjustment (BPA): Humana allows 150 percent of the base amount allowed for *MPFS RVF* bilateral indicator 1 codes reported with a *modifier 50*.

Service code	Modifier	Units	Base amount	Final amount after BPA
aaaaa	50	1	$1000	$1500

Bilateral payment adjustment (BPA) and multiple surgery reduction (MSR): The multiple surgery reduction is applied after the bilateral payment adjustment. For this Medicare Advantage example, Humana plans apply a multiple surgery reduction as follows:

- The procedure with the highest base amount allowed after bilateral payment adjustments is not reduced; and
- All other procedures are reduced by 50 percent.

Therefore, service code bbbbb is allowed at 100 percent of the base amount allowed, service code ccccc is allowed at 50 percent of 150 percent of the base amount allowed and service code ddddd is allowed at 50 percent of the base amount allowed.

Service code	Modifier	Units	Base amount	Amount after BPA	MSR ranking	Final amount after MSR
bbbbb		1	$750	$750	1	$750
ccccc	50	1	$450	$675	2	$337.50
ddddd		1	$500	$500	3	$250

Additional Resources on this Topic

Humana's Making it Easier web-based training series includes videos on the proper reporting of modifier 50 and modifier 59 that may supplement your understanding of this policy.

Definitions of *Italicized* Terms

- ***Base maximum amount payable under the member's plan***: The maximum amount of reimbursement for a covered expense, determined by the member's plan. Depending on the plan, this may be the maximum allowable fee, the appropriate Medicare fee schedule rate or an amount derived from another payment model. Actual plan reimbursement may be less than this base maximum amount, because of applicable adjustments.
- ***Medicare Physician Fee Schedule (MPFS) Relative Value File (RVF)***: A file published by the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS) that includes, among other information, bilateral indicator, relative value units and conversion factors for physician services.
- ***Modifier 50***: Bilateral procedure.
- ***Modifier 59***: Distinct procedural service.
- ***Modifier LT***: Left side (used to identify procedures performed on the left side of the body).
- ***Modifier RT***: Right side (used to identify procedures performed on the right side of the body).

References

- Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services website. Medicare Claims Processing Manual. Chapter 12 – Physicians/Nonphysician Practitioners. Sections 20.4, 40, 40.6 and 40.7. www.cms.gov.
- Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services website. Medicare Claims Processing Manual. Chapter 23 – Fee Schedule Administration and Coding Requirements. Addendum - MPFSDB File Record Layout and Field Descriptions. www.cms.gov.
- Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services website. Medicare Physician Fee Schedule (MPFS) Relative Value Files. www.cms.gov.
- American Medical Association's CPT® and associated publications and services.
- Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services HCPCS Level II and associated publications and services.

General Humana Resources

- Availity – Providers can register for access to information on a variety of topics such as eligibility, benefits, referrals, authorizations, claims and electronic remittances.
- Claims processing edit notifications – Alerts of upcoming claims payment changes are posted on the first Friday of each month.
- Claims resources – Providers can find information on referrals, authorizations, electronic claim submissions and more.
- Making it easier – This page contains an educational series for providers and healthcare professionals.
- Medical and pharmacy coverage policies – Humana publishes determinations of coverage of medical procedures, devices and medications for the treatment of various conditions. There may be variances in coverage among plans.
- Publications – This page can help you find our quarterly newsletter, provider manual and other resources to help you do business with us.

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